

may prosper more by my suffering than by my remaining free.”

Bal Gangadhar Tilak

Freedom fighter 1856-1920

STREET FIGHTER

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■ By Richard Cashman

Bal Gangadhar Tilak was a charismatic and forceful politician and was one of the first popular leaders of Indian Independence. He became known as the Lokamanya (revered by the people) because of his trenchant criticism of British rule and his personal role in resisting it. The son of a schoolteacher, Tilak was born in the Konkan district of Ratnagiri. Many stories from his childhood attest to his precociousness, petulance and independent character. He enrolled at Deccan College, Pune, where he excelled at mathematics and was nicknamed “Blunt” by his fellow collegians, while at college he undertook a daily exercise programme of gymnastics, wrestling, rowing and swimming to strengthen his body.

After graduation, he taught mathematics in Pune before becoming involved in nationalistic educational societies. He then established two nationalist newspapers in the early 1880s, the English-language *Mahratta* and the Marathi-language, *Kesari*. His writing was pointed and pithy and sternly logical. It was during this decade that a split developed in the Congress between the moderates and extremists. The former attempted to appeal to liberal British interests to progressively share power with the western-educated Indian elite. Tilak gravitated towards and became the leader of the second group that rejected the mendicant tactics of

moderates, arguing forthrightly for self-rule and contending that the British would only make real concessions when they were forced to do so.

Tilak developed innovative tactics to advance the cause of the extremists. Instead of making speeches in council halls and composing endless petitions to the British, he developed innovative campaigns that took the Congress cause to the streets. The aim of this campaign was to raise the profile of the Congress party, to give it more clout and to ground the secular and western independence movement more in Indian tradition and culture. In 1893, for instance, he attempted to add a political dimension to the popular Ganapati festival. In 1895 he organised a movement to honour the great 17th century Maharashtrian leader, Shivaji, who wrested territory from the Mughals in western India.

The British believed that Tilak—famously referred to as “the father of the Indian unrest” by Valentine Chirol—incited terrorism by what they regarded as inflammatory articles in *Kesari* and he was jailed for 18 months in 1897. Tilak emerged unrepentant and on his release uttered the memorable phrase: “Swaraj (self-rule) is my birthright and I shall have it”. He was tried again for sedition in 1908 when, recognising that the court provided him a political theatre, he defended himself in a 21-hour speech. Tilak had a loud voice and was a powerful orator. When he was sentenced to six years’ transportation to Mandalay, Burma, the Bombay

workers went on a strike.

When he re-emerged in 1914, he brought regional politics to the all-India stage. He helped found the All India Home Rule League in 1916 with English theosophist Annie Besant and Mohammed Ali Jinnah, the architect of Pakistan. While some have viewed Tilak as a Maratha protagonist and a Hindu nationalist, his political views were rather more complex and evolved over time. Although socially conservative in many respects, Tilak, in later life, expressed an admiration for Lenin after the Russian Revolution of 1917. Although he became popular outside Maharashtra, he never became a national politician in the sense that Mahatma Gandhi did. Tilak was constrained by the limited means of communication and transportation.

There could be no greater contrast between the proud, strong and this-worldly Maharashtrian and the ascetically-inclined Gandhi—Tilak was a scholar, who published a work on *The Artistic Home of the Vedas*, whereas Gandhi was not. Tilak also had reservations about Gandhi’s tactics of non-violence. His bold stance and innovative campaigns to enlist people paved the way for Gandhi. When Tilak died in 1920 and Gandhi joined some 2,00,000 mourners in Bombay for his cremation, he said Tilak was “the maker of modern India”.

The author is an adjunct professor at the University of Technology, Sydney. He has written The Myth of the Lokamanya: Tilak and Mass Politics in Maharashtra (1975).